

RULES/TIPS FOR READY PLAY IN CURLING

The Mission for all Positions

Pre-game

Be on time: One person late is not a manageable issue but two people late on the same team will delay the start of your game.

Use the pregame time to your advantage: While you cannot start your game before -5:00 minutes on the clock and the ice crew is finished and ready to play, you can get a lot of other things out of the way:

- Make sure all your equipment (stabilizers, sliders, sticks, etc.) are in place at both ends of the ice.
- Get your coin toss done. While the convention at our club is to have the Leads do it, this is not a hard and fast rule. Have the non-hammer team select a rock color as well. Both these activities can also be done in the warm room before going on the ice.
- Wish each other good curling.
- Get your practice slides completed.
- Non-hammer Skip can have their first call communicated to their Lead before they head to the playing end.

In-game

It's a spirit of curling thing: Everybody deserves to know the game will be 8 ends long and can manage their game plan accordingly. This avoids situations where there is a significant score differential and the team in the lead then milks the clock. We have to put people on the clock to move the game along but it should not be a determining factor of getting a full game in. Don't deprive your opponent of the chance to earn points toward an end-of-season award.

Wasted time: As little as 10 seconds of wasted time per delivery over 8 ends means you won't get 8 ends in. It'll cost the teams over 21 minutes which translates to about an end-and-a-half.

Clearing rocks at the completion of an end: Just push them into the corral and do not worry about order. If you are now the non-hammer team, help your Lead out by getting the first rock they throw to the hack for them.

Moving rocks to the hack: Help each other out here. For example, if someone is retrieving a stabilizer, move their rock to the hack for them.

Hack routine: Clean your rock as soon as possible after sliding it to the hack. Don't wait for the Skip's call and then clean it. You'll waste time standing there. How long do you spend in the hack setting up your delivery? Can you reduce it and still be effective?

After delivery: Take a couple of seconds to observe the position of rocks at the playing end and then quickly clear out of the other team's way. Sweepers should move out to the sidelines and then move to the hog line at the delivery end and wait for the other team to throw.

Watching the game from your ready position: Don't stand at the hog line and watch the other team's stone go down the ice. Move quickly to get ready to play and observe from there.

Use a stabilizer?: If it's a club stabilizer, make sure you are not holding on to it if someone throwing right after you needs it (your team or your opponent's). Pass it safely to them without delay so that they can get set up for their shot. *Longer term goal: Consider switching to using a broom for your slide. Ultimately, it is the more versatile choice. Need help with that? Consult one of our instructors. Any of them would be glad to work with you.*

Post-game

We have the technology! All games are streamed on YouTube and available immediately after they conclude. Didn't get a full 8 ends in? Take a minute and review the game to see if there are ways you can improve your own pace of play. You don't need to watch the whole game (but you could). Watch your shots. How much time are you spending? How much time is the Skip spending making decisions? Did you help others on the team to move the game along?

War stories: Take a few minutes to review any delays as part of your post-game review. Ask questions about calls, observations, etc. You can do this before you sit down to broomstack or as part of broomstacking itself, whatever makes most sense. You might be surprised by what you learn; maybe even pleasantly surprised.

Deeds for the Leads

Don't have the hammer when starting an end? Don't worry about moving rocks back to the corral. If you use a stabilizer or stick, grab that first and then find your rock and get to the hack and clean it.

Move the Skip's rocks to the hack: When it's their turn to throw, make sure their rocks are in place for them while they are making their call with the Vice at the other end of the ice.

Ask the Skip if it's ok to clean their rock for them: This is not a requirement as technically the Skip should clean their own rock nor should a Skip require you to but because the Skip typically spends the most time delivering their rock, it can help reduce the time.

Weapons for the Seconds

Think of yourself as a second Lead: While the Lead has the responsibility of moving the Skip's rocks to the hack, depending on the side of the ice you're on, you might be closer to your team's rocks and can help with this activity. Or maybe the Lead had to tie their shoelace...

Be the clock cop for your team: You are the assistant to the Skip in this regard. They are the clock boss, and should be managing accordingly, but you can help by pointing out when the team is behind. Help save your team precious seconds – it's right in your title.

Advice for the Vice

Taking over the house: After delivering your second rock, get down to the other end of the ice as quickly as possible without interfering with the other team's delivery. If you're the non-hammer Vice, then you may have to wait to go behind the other Vice's delivery but if you are the hammer team's Vice you can go immediately after your delivery as you will have time while the non-hammer team is making their call and getting ready to deliver. This is the time to offer the Skip any insights on next shots and start discussing them.

Whose house is it anyway? It's still the Skip's house until they throw their rocks. Vices should only be more concerned about defensive sweeping when the Skip is throwing and then for being a secondary sweeper if there is an opportunity to sweep a second rock when the Skip stops sweeping theirs.

Is that measure necessary? Nothing steals time from your game like a measure. There will be times when you can't decide visually and need to measure but do your best to avoid these situations. If the Vices can agree without it, especially if the difference of 1 point is not all that important, you save yourself at least a minute or two on the clock.

Posting scores: If you are posting a score, it's because you just won the end which means you are now the non-hammer team. Your priority is to be ready for play. If your Skip is ready to make a call and your front end is ready to throw, don't hold them up; post the score as soon as possible after the Lead's first rock. Otherwise, if there's any delay and you have an opportunity, post the score as soon as rocks are back in the corrals.

Tips for the Skips

First call for an end: If you're the non-hammer team, have your call for the next end ready at the completion of the current end and communicate it to your Lead before you head to the other end of the ice.

Your turn: Even without taking "unnecessary" time to make a call and deliver your own stones, you will already typically be the person who takes the most time to take your turn throwing. The average time required to get 128 rocks thrown in a game is 56.25 seconds per rock. If your front end and Vice are throwing a bit faster than that, which they should easily be able to do, then you might be able to get away with 60-70 seconds, but anything more than that more than a few times during the game pretty much guarantees you're not getting 8 ends in. You'd be surprised how long a minute is.

Economize discussions with the Vice: Accept their perspectives and alternatives, decide quickly, and make sure they understand the intended outcome and a plan B, but don't get into an endless discussion of all the things that could possibly happen. Save those for the warm room. Remember, calling the game is your responsibility.

You are the clock boss: Focus on getting through an end at the 15-minute pace. You have 5 minutes of grace at the beginning if you start ahead of time and 5 minutes of grace at the end since you can still start the 8th end with 10:00 left but if you get behind just 1 minute beyond that pace per end, finishing with 8 ends is in jeopardy. Don't fall for that old saw that (sarcastically) states: "the sooner you get behind, the more time you have to catch up."

Arithmetic elimination: Once your game is arithmetically impossible to win, it is over. According to WC rules, if it is not the 8th end (or last end if you don't have time for an 8th end), you can complete the end. If you are in the 8th/last end, the game is over immediately, and the eliminated Skip would offer their hand at that time. Do not complete the end. No exceptions.

Concessions: In the unfortunate situation that the score differential is big, consider a concession, especially after 6 ends. If you want to practice beyond that, you can, but any additional time should not impact another league getting on the ice at its assigned time.